I remember asking Priyanka's secretary Preeti Sahai whether it was worth my coming to Amethi and seeking an interview. 'For now, no interviews. She will only give sound bites while on the campaign,' I was firmly told. 2014 was no 1999. Then, there were just a handful of cameras. Now, with hundreds of news channels around, getting an exclusive with Priyanka was that much more difficult.

The sound bites, too, were well choreographed, designed to create just enough news to keep the hungry bite-soldiers (as we referred to our reporters) feeling happy and also to take potshots at the BJP leadership: 'You don't need a 56-inch chest to run India but a big heart!' 'How can a person who snoops on other women respect the Indian woman!' Her best Indira Gandhi-style regally dismissive remark about the BJP was that they were 'running around like panic-stricken rats'. For news channels, these sound bites made perfect headlines. Priyanka Gandhi taking on Modi became an almost regular sideshow for about a fortnight in the larger electoral battleground.

Priyanka's punchy remarks seemed to get under Modi's skin. He hit back and, unsurprisingly, Robert Vadra was the Achilles heel he targeted. 'The UPA model of governance is RSVP (Rahul, Sonia, Vadra, Priyanka). How did one person multiply his earnings from one lakh to 400 crores in five years?' he asked. The BJP's media department even prepared a video detailing Vadra's land transactions.

Right through her campaign, Priyanka did not take any direct questions on her husband—a dismissive gesture with the hand and a suggestion that this was a 'bunch of lies by panic-stricken people' was all that she was willing to say. I got the sense that one reason she didn't want to do a lengthy interview was the fear that the Vadra question would inevitably crop up.

I had briefly encountered Vadra at a couple of social events but never really spoken to him. Often dressed in black, with a tight belt, manicured moustache and a well-toned body, he looked more like a trendy dance show contestant in an *India's Got Talent* show than a businessman (I am told Priyanka was swayed by his dancing charms when she first met him!).